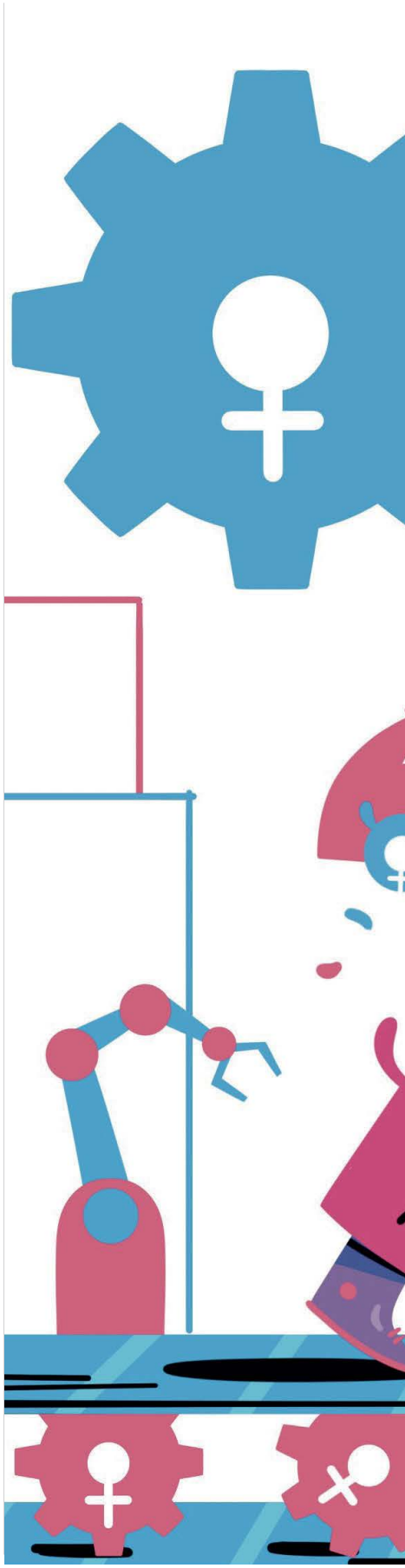
Doors EVs Open

As the auto industry moves increasingly to electric mobility, women are finding new opportunities in leadership and on the factory floor

BY **KARAN DHAR**



WHEN SUMAN MISHRA took charge of Mahindra Group's last-mile mobility business as chief executive in August 2021, she was in for a surprise. "Somebody called up and said you are the first woman professional CEO in the auto industry," Mishra tells *BT*.

"I almost fell off my chair. I'm like, what are you saying? Are you saying the automotive industry in India hasn't had professional female CEOs?" she recalls. "It was a shock."

Women's participation in the auto industry was so low that when Mishra began visiting manufacturing plants as CEO, she would ask a simple question: Where was the women's washroom? Often, there wasn't one. "Nobody's there. Nobody uses it," she recalls being told. By her second visit, a washroom would have been installed and a few women employees introduced to her. "We have hired three-four women," she remembers being told. From then on, Mishra made it a point to take a photograph with women employees during plant visits. Their numbers gradually rose until they outgrew the room where they used to gather.

The once-in-a-generation shift to electric mobility is beginning to change the equation, creating opportunities for newer players—and potentially more women—in an industry long dominated by men.

For Aanchal Jain, CEO of KKR-backed electric bus maker PMI Electro Mobility, electrification has transformed the auto industry's landscape. "When the electrification of buses was happening in 2016-17, that was sort of a democratic movement. What legacy players had was the engine, and with electrification, the engine went away," she says. At the time, her family busi-